Preparation plan: presentation on Wednesday 18 November 2026

Written on Wednesday 28 October, so there are **21 days**. About 60 to 90 minutes a day is enough; the plan front-loads understanding, then repetition aloud, then performance. Everything referred to here is in `presentation_new/`: the deck, `PRESENTER_GUIDE.md` (cues and the one-page cue card), and `QA_DRILL.md`.

The goal, in one line

Be able to say the whole talk in your own words, to time, and to answer any question with **one sentence, one number, one honest limit**.

Things to confirm this week (they change the plan)

- **Dr Tian's reply** to the draft deck. Apply his feedback by Wednesday 4 November; tell me and I will update the deck.
- **Does the 30 to 40 minutes include questions?** The talk is built to 33.5 minutes. If questions are inside the slot, `PRESENTER_GUIDE.md` lists what to cut first.
- **The marking rubric** for the oral. If clarity, timing or questions carry marks, weight your rehearsal toward them.
- **Logistics:** room or online, time, who is on the panel, whether you bring your own laptop, the screen ratio, and whether the slides must be submitted beforehand.

Three phases

Phase 1, Know it (Wed 28 Oct to Tue 3 Nov)

Day	Do this	Time
Wed 28 Oct	Send the email to Dr Tian. Read `PRESENTER_GUIDE.md` once. Learn the spine: **the dial matters more than the detector** (50 points against about 5).	45 min
Thu 29 Oct	Re-read the report chapters you will be examined on: 4 (results), 5 (discussion), 6 (conclusion). Then write the 30-second, 2-minute and 5-minute versions of the talk from memory (see below).	90 min
Fri 30 Oct	First slow read-through of all 34 slides with the notes in front of you, no timer. Mark every slide where you hesitate.	60 min
Sat 31	Learn the numbers table at the bottom of `QA_DRILL.md`. Cover and recite it.	45 min

Day	Do this	Time
Oct		
Sun 1 Nov	Rest, or only read the Q&A drill, tiers A and B.	30 min
Mon 2 Nov	**Run-through 1**, aloud, with a timer, notes allowed. Write down your time at slides 5, 16, 28 and 34.	60 min
Tue 3 Nov	Fix the slides you hesitated on, with me if you like.	45 min

Phase 2, Say it (Wed 4 Nov to Tue 10 Nov)

Day	Do this	Time
Wed 4 Nov	**Deck freeze v1:** apply Dr Tian's feedback.	45 min
Thu 5 Nov	**Run-through 2**, timed. Notes only for the middle of the talk; slides 1 to 5 and 25 to 28 from memory. Record the audio on your phone.	60 min
Fri 6 Nov	Listen back. Mark filler words, rushed slides, and places you read from the slide. Q&A drill, tiers A and B, aloud.	60 min
Sat 7 Nov	**Run-through 3**, standing, with a clicker or the arrow keys, no notes except the cue card. Target 30 to 34 minutes.	60 min
Sun 8 Nov	Rest.	
Mon 9 Nov	**Rehearse for someone outside mathematics.** Test: can they say the main finding back in one sentence? Ask them for three questions you did not expect.	60 min
Tue 10 Nov	Q&A drill, tiers C and D, with me as a hostile examiner.	60 min

Phase 3, Perform it (Wed 11 Nov to Tue 17 Nov)

Day	Do this	Time
Wed 11 Nov	**Dress rehearsal 1:** full talk without stopping, phone timer, no notes, in the clothes and space you will use if you can.	45 min

Day	Do this	Time
Thu 12 Nov	Mock questions with Dr Tian, a peer or a friend who knows the area.	60 min
Fri 13 Nov	**Last day to change any slide.** Final tweaks only.	45 min
Sat 14 Nov	**Final deck freeze.** Export the PDF. Make three copies: USB stick, email to yourself, cloud. Print the one-page cue card.	30 min
Sun 15 Nov	Light: say the opening and the closing aloud three times.	20 min
Mon 16 Nov	**Dress rehearsal 2:** full talk, filmed on your phone; watch it back with the sound off to check posture and pointing.	45 min
Tue 17 Nov	Light: opening, closing and slide 28 only. Pack the bag. Sleep early.	20 min
Wed 18 Nov	**The day** (below).	

How to rehearse (the method that works)

1. **Aloud and standing.** Reading in your head is not rehearsal; your mouth needs the practice.
2. **Four stages, in order:** read the notes; use only bullets; use only slide titles and takeaways; use nothing. Move down a stage only when the one above is easy.
3. **Say the takeaway bar in your own words** before you leave each slide. That is the habit that keeps you on message.
4. **Never read the slide.** The slide is for the audience; you are the explanation.
5. **Pause for two seconds after a headline number.** Say it, stop, let it land: *0.379 to 0.881*.
6. **Time at checkpoints**, not just at the end. The clock should read about: slide 5 at 4 min, slide 16 at 17 min, slide 28 at 29 min, slide 33 at 34 min (the guide lists the exact running totals).
7. **Record yourself once a week** and count the filler words. Two minutes of listening is worth an hour of repeating.

Memorise these word for word

The first 45 seconds (slide 1): > “Good morning. I asked how well machine learning can forecast hazardous air quality days in Delhi. The answer I want to build to is on the right: the number of alarms a health authority is willing to raise matters many times more than which model produces the forecast. I will take you through the data, the models, my three research questions, and what I would and would not claim.”

The last 45 seconds (slide 33): > “My recommendation is to design a hazardous air quality warning system around the alarm budget its operator can justify, with the forecasting model a secondary refinement. A comparison of models that does not fix the alarm budget has answered a question nobody who operates the system asked.

Thank you; I am happy to take questions."

The talk at three lengths (write these from memory in Phase 1, then check against this):

- *30 seconds:* "I forecast hazardous PM2.5 days in Delhi one to three days ahead using twelve models, and judged them as a warning system. A classical model, ARIMA, beats every machine learning regressor; neural networks win only at one day ahead. But the biggest finding is that the number of alarms allowed moves the hit rate by about fifty points, and the choice of model by only a few."
- *2 minutes:* add the data (one Delhi monitor, ten years, two defects fixed), the protocol (2,303 rolling-origin forecasts, leakage-tested, networks as ten-seed ranges), and the three answers (RQ1, RQ2 21/11/4, RQ3 50 against about 5).
- *5 minutes:* add why it matters (health threshold 121), the smoke-alarm picture, the limits, and the recommendation.

Answering questions (the formula)

1. **Listen to the end. Pause. Restate** the question in one short phrase if it is long.
2. **Answer first** in one sentence.
3. **Give one number** from the report.
4. **State the limit** honestly before they do.
5. **Stop.** Do not fill the silence.

When you do not know: *"I have not tested that. My expectation is X, because Y. It is on my list of future work, and I would test it by Z."* Never bluff; a clear "not tested" scores better than a vague answer.

When the question is hostile: keep your voice slow and say "that is a fair challenge" if it is. Then use the formula. Most hostile questions are one of: *isn't it trivial*, *is it significant*, *is it representative*, *did you tune fairly*. All four are in `QA_DRILL.md`.

Use the backup slides. Say "I have that in a backup slide", go to it (B1 to B10 are listed on the last slide), and answer from the table.

If things go wrong

Problem	What to do
Running long	At the end of Methods (slide 16) the clock should read about 17 minutes. If you are 2 minutes over, cut slides 12, 23 and 30 (the guide says how).
Mind goes blank	Look at the takeaway bar and say it. Then the next slide title. The cue card is on the desk.
Laptop or projector fails	Open the PDF from the USB stick or email. The PDF has no animations, so nothing breaks.

Problem	What to do
Question you cannot answer	The “do not know” formula, then move on.
Nerves	Breathe out slowly for six seconds before you start; the opening is memorised, so the first minute is automatic.

The day, Wednesday 18 November

- Arrive 30 minutes early. Test the laptop, the connection and the clicker. Open the **PDF** as well as the deck.
- Check the room clock or set a phone timer at the front where you can see it.
- Water, the printed cue card, a pen, your student ID.
- Walk through the first three slides in your head; say the opening aloud once quietly.
- During the talk: pause on headline numbers; point with your hand, not your eyes; face the panel.
- At the end: say thank you, take questions with the formula, and thank them again.

What I can do with you next

- **Mock examiner:** say “start mock viva” and I will ask questions from `QA_DRILL.md` one at a time, push back, and mark your answers.
- **Update the deck** after Dr Tian replies.
- **Cut to a shorter version** if questions are inside the slot.